

Plant Systems Career Evidence Guide

NAME

DATE

PERIOD

Three ways people improve plant and food systems

All pay figures are **May 2024 U.S. median annual wages**. They are not starting pay and not DFW-local wages. Outlook figures are national projections for **2024-2034**.

CAREER	WHAT THE WORKER DOES	TYPICAL ENTRY ROUTE	2024 U.S. MEDIAN	2024-34 OUTLOOK
Agricultural and Food Science Technician	Helps scientists test plants, soil, food, and production methods; records samples and data	Usually an associate degree; entry routes vary and may include related experience	\$48,480	5% growth
Soil and Plant Scientist	Studies soil, crops, pests, water, and growing methods to improve plant production and protect resources	At least a bachelor's degree in plant biology, agriculture, or a related field	\$71,410	5% growth
Agricultural Engineer	Designs and tests equipment, structures, environmental controls, irrigation, and automated farm systems	Bachelor's degree in agricultural, biological, or another engineering field	\$84,630	6% growth

READ THE MEASURES CORRECTLY

- **Median** means half of workers earn more and half earn less. It does not predict a new worker's first salary.
- **Outlook** is a national projection, not a promise that every local employer will hire.
- A specialty such as hydroponics, precision agriculture, or controlled-environment growing may sit inside a broader occupation. Job titles vary.
- More education can expand responsibility and pay, but it also requires more time, cost, and preparation.

FIRST LOOK

Role with the shortest typical route: Highest median:

One role that combines agriculture and technology:

Irving ISD curriculum connection

The *Find Your Future* workbook is the student-facing curriculum source for the Plant Science opportunities at Nimitz High School. Use the program names, activities, and experiences as the workbook presents them so the guide stays aligned with the material students have in hand.

The current Irving ISD CTE page is a teacher cross-check for public-facing updates. It should not silently replace or contradict your *Find Your Future* workbook during the lesson. If a future public update creates a real instructional conflict, flag it for curriculum review.

Important boundary: A high-school pathway can build knowledge, experience, and connections. It does not guarantee a certification, job, salary, admission, or college credit.

SOURCES CHECKED AUGUST 8, 2026

- U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Agricultural and Food Science Technicians; Agricultural and Food Scientists; Agricultural Engineers. Pay: May 2024. Outlook: 2024-2034.
- Irving ISD, Nimitz High School Career and Technical Education page.

Use the evidence

Which role would be most involved in testing a failing hydroponic system? Use one duty and one education fact.

What is one trade-off between the route with the shortest preparation and the route with the highest median pay?

What is one fact you would still need before choosing a route for yourself?
